

Post-incident review PIR-2025-058

Customer Portal: partial outage

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 24 March 2025, Customer Portal experienced partial outage in production (AU East) for about 18 minutes. Users posted about the problem on social media, and the support team escalated it. Investigation found that the database ran out of connections under end-of-month batch load.

Impact

Users of Customer Portal saw partial outage for about 18 minutes. The service owner, Digital Channels, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:02 First signal received.
- 09:38 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:43 Likely cause identified.
- 10:00 Mitigation applied.
- 10:40 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that the database ran out of connections under end-of-month batch load.

Certificates were checked as part of triage and were valid.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

The relevant alert had fired repeatedly the previous week and had been muted by the on-call engineer.

All traffic depended on one component with no standby.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Add a circuit breaker and timeout on the upstream call.
- Exercise the rollback path in staging as part of every release.
- Write and rehearse a runbook for this failure mode.